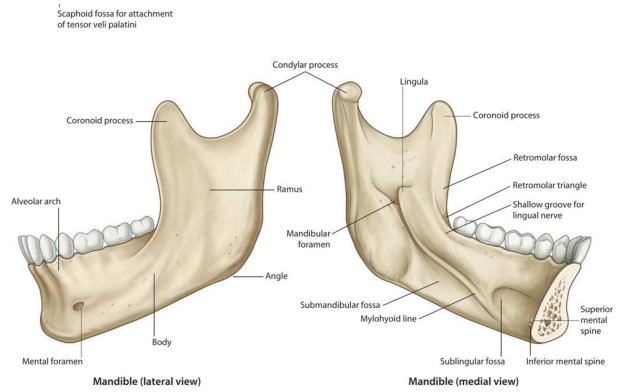
Mandible

Parts, surfaces, foramina, muscle attachments and nerves of the lower jaw, with how it changes with age.

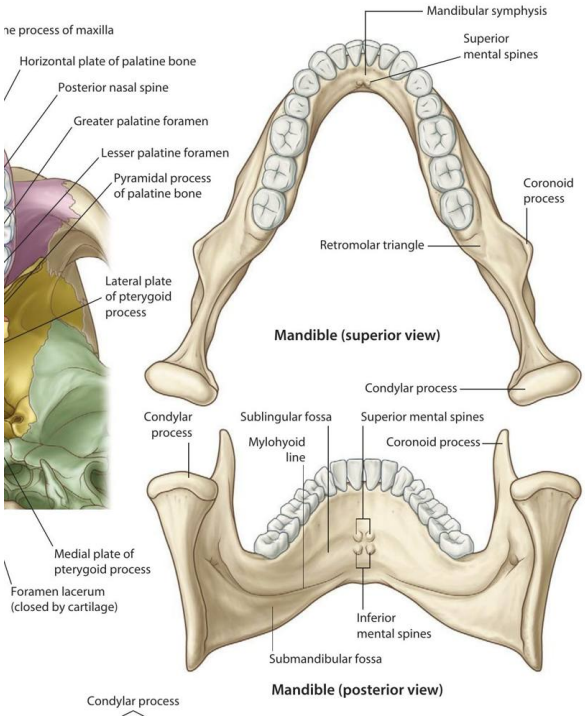
Parts of the mandible

- **A horseshoe-shaped body** and **two rami**, meeting at the **angle** on each side.
- **Ramus:** ends above in the **coronoid process** (front) and **condylar process** (back), separated by the **mandibular notch**.
- **Body:** an upper **alveolar part** carrying the teeth and a lower **base**.
- **In the midline:** symphysis menti and the mental protuberance, with a mental tubercle on each side.

Clinical pearl: The mandible develops around Meckel's cartilage of the first arch but is mostly formed by membranous ossification.



Mandible (lateral and medial views). Gray's Atlas of Anatomy, 2nd ed., p. 572

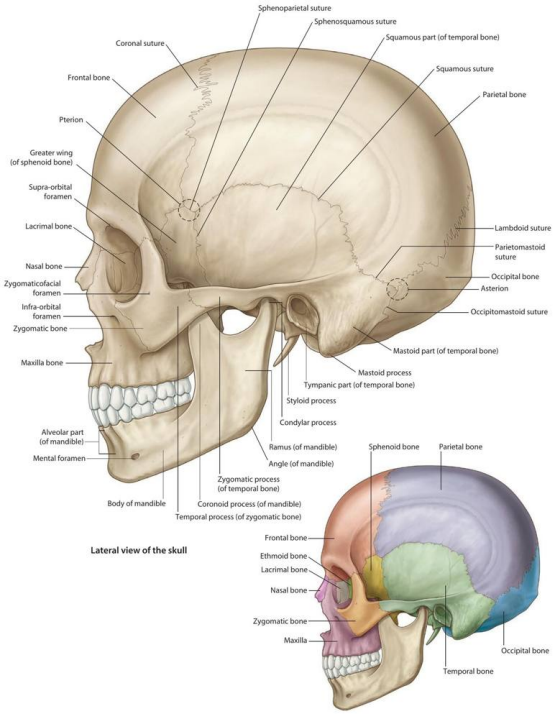


Mandible (superior and posterior views). Gray's Atlas of Anatomy, 2nd ed., p. 572

Outer surface

- **Mental foramen:** near the apex of the second premolar, midway between the upper and lower borders in the dentate adult. Transmits the mental nerve and vessels.
- **Oblique line:** runs from the anterior border of the ramus onto the body. Gives origin to depressor labii inferioris and depressor anguli oris; buccinator arises beside the molar teeth.
- **Lateral ramus and angle:** masseter.
- **Incisive fossa:** mentalis. **Lower border:** platysma.

Clinical pearl: The facial artery crosses the lower border at the front of masseter, where you can feel its pulse.

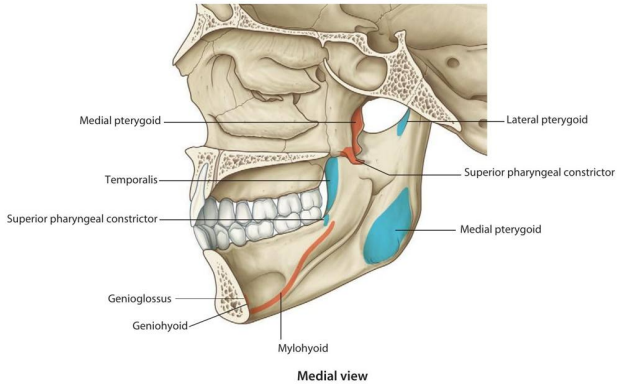


Lateral view of the skull: squamous, tympanic and mastoid parts. Gray's Atlas of Anatomy, 2nd ed., p. 480

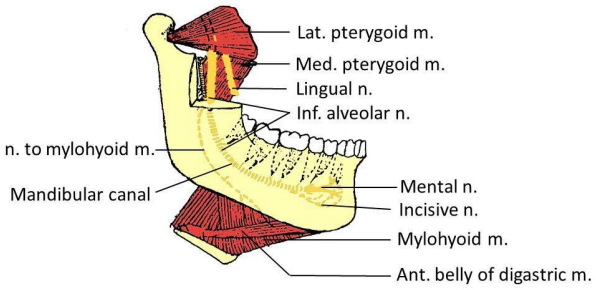
Inner surface

- **Mandibular foramen:** centre of the medial ramus. Transmits the **inferior alveolar nerve and vessels**.
- **Lingula:** a tongue of bone in front of the foramen. Gives attachment to the **sphenomandibular ligament**.
- **Mylohyoid groove:** below and behind the foramen, for the nerve to mylohyoid and its vessels.
- **Mylohyoid line:** gives origin to mylohyoid. **Sublingual fossa** lies above its front part, **submandibular fossa** below its back part.
- **Superior mental spine:** genioglossus. **Inferior mental spine:** geniohyoid. **Digastric fossa:** anterior belly of digastric.
- **Medial angle:** medial pterygoid. **Behind the last molar:** pterygomandibular raphe and superior constrictor.

Clinical pearl: The lingual nerve lies against the bone just below and behind the third molar, so it is at risk during extraction.



Mandible, medial view: pterygoid and constrictor attachments. Gray's Atlas of Anatomy, 2nd ed., p. 489

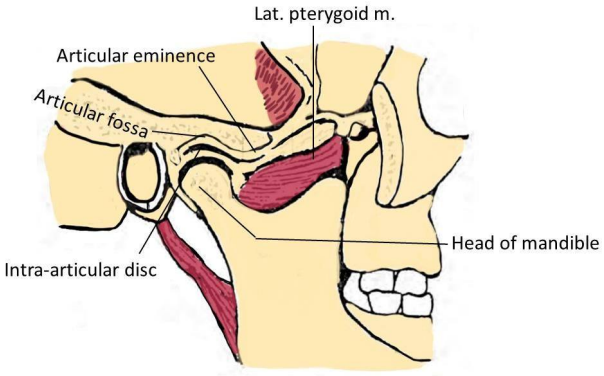


Inferior alveolar nerve and nerve to mylohyoid. Dr. Sameh Doss handout, p. 58

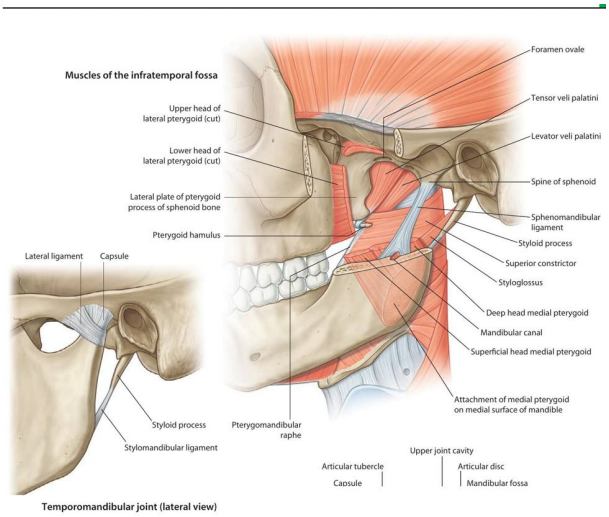
Condyle, coronoid and notch

- **Head of the condyle:** articulates through the disc with the mandibular fossa and articular tubercle.
- **Pterygoid fovea:** a pit on the front of the neck, for the **lateral pterygoid**.
- **Coronoid process: temporalis**, on its tip and medial surface, extending down to the retromolar fossa.
- **Mandibular notch:** transmits the **masseteric nerve and vessels**.
- **Medial to the neck:** the auriculotemporal nerve and maxillary artery.

Clinical pearl: Anterior dislocation occurs when the condyle passes in front of the articular tubercle.



Temporomandibular joint: articular disc and lateral pterygoid. Dr. Sameh Doss handout, p. 199

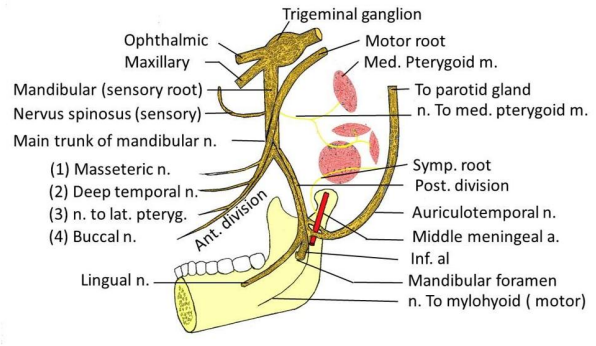


Temporomandibular joint (lateral view) and muscles of the infratemporal fossa. Gray's Atlas of Anatomy, 2nd ed., p. 529

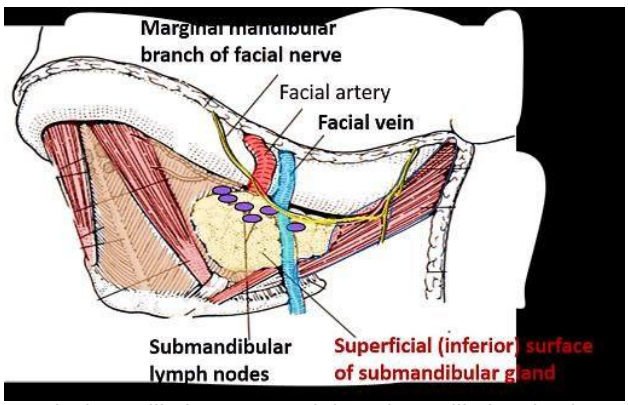
Nerves related to the mandible

- **Inferior alveolar nerve:** enters the mandibular foramen, runs in the canal, supplies the lower teeth, then divides into **mental** and **incisive** branches.
- **Nerve to mylohyoid:** leaves before the foramen; supplies mylohyoid and the anterior belly of digastric.
- **Lingual nerve:** medial to the ramus, then beside the third molar, into the floor of the mouth.
- **Marginal mandibular branch of VII:** runs near the lower border, superficial to the facial vessels. **Auriculotemporal nerve:** behind the neck.

Clinical pearl: Lower lip numbness after mandibular surgery or fracture suggests inferior alveolar or mental nerve injury.



Mandibular nerve: trunk, divisions and branches. Dr. Sameh Doss handout, p. 55

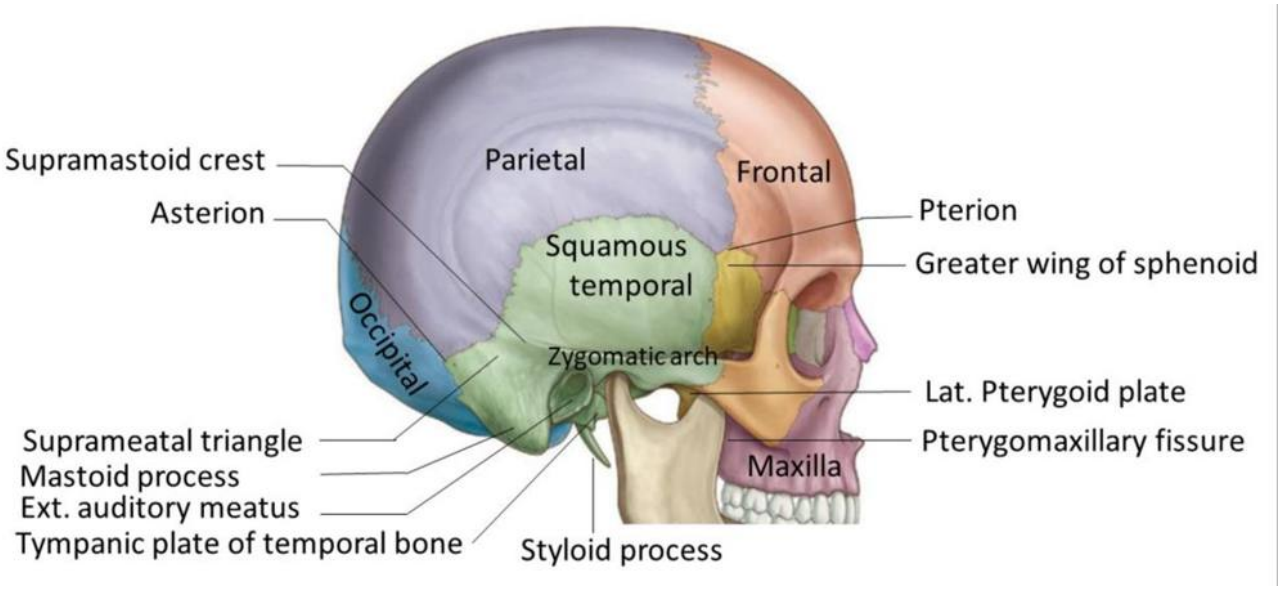


Marginal mandibular nerve and the submandibular gland. ENT Steps Anatomy, p. 190

Age changes and clinical points

- **Angle:** obtuse in the infant, about **110–120°** in the adult, and obtuse again in the edentulous elderly (about 140°).
- **Mental foramen:** near the lower border in the infant, midway in the dentate adult, and near the upper edge after alveolar bone is lost.
- **Symphysis:** the two halves fuse in about the first year of life.
- **Fracture sites:** condylar neck, angle, body and parasymphysis are the common ones, often in combination.

Clinical pearl: Retromolar trigone cancer lies directly on the mandible, so it can invade bone early.



Lateral skull: pterion, asterion and the infratemporal surface. Dr. Sameh Doss handout, p. 9

Muscle attachments on the mandible

Site	Muscle or ligament	Nerve
Lateral ramus and angle	Masseter	V3
Coronoid process	Temporalis	V3
Pterygoid fovea	Lateral pterygoid	V3
Medial angle	Medial pterygoid	V3
Mylohyoid line	Mylohyoid	Nerve to mylohyoid (V3)
Digastric fossa	Anterior belly of digastric	Nerve to mylohyoid (V3)
Superior mental spine	Genioglossus	XII
Inferior mental spine	Geniohyoid	C1 via XII
Lingula	Sphenomandibular ligament	Not applicable

Notes are a study summary of standard anatomy. Check them against your course material. Personal study use.